

3.4.1 Strategies for understanding

3.4.1.1 Ignoring words which are not needed

Many tasks contain words which are not essential for an understanding of the main points of the text. What is important in the text is often presented more than once, in different ways: the student may not understand a point in one form of words and understand it fully in another.

3.4.1.2 Using the visual and verbal context

The skilled reader can find many clues about the purpose and content of a text from a study of the layout, the title, the length, the typeface and any related pictures.

When reading and listening, students can learn to infer the meaning of new words from the verbal context.

In the following examples a student could be expected to make a deduction about the word in bold type from the verbal context.

*Neue Sportarten wie Rafting und **Splanch** werden immer populärer (a sport).*

*Die **Eiche** war der größte Baum im Garten (a type of tree).*

*Der **Dom** ist viel größer als andere Kirchen in Ulm (a kind of church).*

3.4.1.3 Making use of grammatical markers and categories

Students will be helped to master all these strategies if, when reading and listening, they learn to use such clues as the plural forms of nouns and verbs, the way verbs change to form tenses, word order and other such features to help them recognise to which category (verb, noun, adjective etc) an unknown word belongs. This can be a considerable help in making intelligent guesses about the meaning of the word.

In the sentence *Schlafzimmer im ersten Stock haben eine Dusche*, the plural form of the verb underlines that 'bedrooms' is a plural word.

3.4.1.4 Making use of the social and cultural context

Another aid to the drawing of correct inferences is for students to bear in mind that there are regularities in the real world which make it possible to anticipate what people may say or write about it. The ability to predict occurrences in the real world makes it possible to anticipate words, and their meaning, in a given context. This is one reason why it is important for a German course to develop awareness and understanding of countries and communities where German is spoken.

3.4.1.5 Using common patterns within German

Knowledge of the following patterns of word formation in German can help to understand a text.

- *un-* prefix (eg *unmöglich, unglücklich*)
- *-in* suffix (eg *Freundin, Engländerin*)
- *-ung* suffix (eg *Wanderung, Wohnung*)
- *-er* suffix (eg *Arbeiter, Physiker*)
- *-chen* suffix (eg *Häuschen, Kätzchen*)
- *-heit* suffix (eg *Krankheit, Faulheit*)
- *-keit* suffix (eg *Freundlichkeit, Ehrlichkeit*)
- *-schaft* suffix (eg *Freundschaft, Weltmeisterschaft*)
- *ab-* prefix (eg *abfahren, abholen*)
- *auf-* prefix (eg *aufstehen, aufgeben*)
- *aus-* prefix (eg *ausgehen, Ausfahrt*)
- *ein-* prefix (eg *einsteigen, Eintritt*)
- *durch-* prefix (eg *durchfahren, durchschneiden*)
- *mit-* prefix (eg *mitgehen, mitnehmen*)
- *an-* prefix (eg *ankommen, anziehen*)
- *um-* prefix (eg *umsteigen, umziehen*)
- *zu-* prefix (eg *zuhören, Zuschauer*)
- verbs with embedded adjectives (eg *verbessern, beruhigen*)
- infinitives used as gerunds (eg *das Schwimmen, das Wandern*)
- using the component parts of compound nouns (eg *Esszimmer, Haustür, Schülerzeitung, Straßenbahnhaltestelle*).

3.4.1.6 Using cognates and near-cognates

A few 'false friends' (eg *also, Gymnasium*) make it necessary to use this strategy with care and in collaboration with the strategy of using the visual and verbal context above. However, for each 'false friend' there are very many 'good friends' of which anglophone learners of German can make good use. These fall into two main categories: cognates and near-cognates.

Cognates

There are many words which have exactly the same form, and essentially the same meaning, in German and in English (eg *Museum, Hand, Name*). When such words occur in a context and students can be expected to understand them in English and German.

Near-cognates

Students will also be expected to understand words which meet the above criteria, but which differ slightly in their written form in German (eg *Adresse, Knie*).

3.4.1.7 Using common patterns between German and English

There are many words in German which, although neither cognates nor near-cognates, can easily be understood with the application of a few, simple rules. When words which can be understood using the rules below occur in context, students will be expected to understand them.

Pattern	Examples
Words where <i>ch</i> in German is replaced by 'k' in English	<i>Koch, machen</i>

Pattern	Examples
Words where <i>t</i> in German is replaced by 'd' in English	<i>trinken, Tropfen</i>
Words where <i>d</i> in German is replaced by 'th' in English	<i>das, danken</i>
Words where <i>pf</i> in German is replaced by 'p' in English	<i>Pfund, Pfeffer</i>
Words where <i>b</i> in German is replaced by 'f/v' in English	<i>Dieb, sieben</i>
Words where <i>ss</i> in German is replaced by 't' in English	<i>Wasser, hasse</i>
Words where <i>cht</i> in German is replaced by 'ght' in English	<i>Nacht, Flucht</i>
Words where <i>z</i> in German is replaced by 't' in English	<i>Zunge, zehn</i>
Words where <i>g</i> in German is replaced by 'y' in English	<i>gestern, gelb</i>
Words where <i>v</i> in German is replaced by 'f' in English	<i>Vater, Volk</i>

Strategies such as those above will be more easily applied in reading than in listening, as reading offers more opportunities to slow down, to look at unknown items at leisure and study the context. Words which **look** the same in two languages may **sound** quite different (eg *Station, Religion*).

Some grammatical markers are more difficult to hear than to see. The comprehension of some plural nouns could depend on the recognition of a different article or the pronunciation of a preceding adjective (eg *das neue Zimmer – die neuen Zimmer*).

In order to hear accurately, students should have the specific differences of the spoken language brought to their attention.

However, some of the general strategies for understanding listed above can, with practice, be used successfully in listening, namely:

- ignoring words which are not needed for a successful completion of the task set
- using the (visual and) verbal context
- making use of the social and cultural context
- using common patterns within German.

In addition, the following strategies are included for listening and understanding, (in place of reading the above strategies regarding cognates and common patterns between German and English).

3.4.1.8 Near-cognates

Although there may be few German words which sound exactly like their English equivalents, there are many near-cognates which are relatively easily recognised. Many English words have been absorbed into German, and are easily recognised (eg *Party, Manager, Job, Bar, Ketchup*). Other words are sufficiently similar in sound to be regarded as near-cognates (eg *Finger, Supermarkt, Student*).

Some words which in reading cause no problem can be very difficult to recognise in speech (eg *Religion, Ingenieur, Instrument*).

However, provided that certain relationships between sound patterns in German and English are recognised, then German words with a clearly 'different' pronunciation to English can be understood. Examples of patterns where a communicative strategy can be applied include the following:

- the characteristic pronunciation of *-tion* in words such as *Station, Nation*
- the primary stress pattern of words such as *Atom, Energie, Präsident, Elektrizität*
- voiced consonants at the end of words in English are often devoiced in German (eg *Bart, Bett, Pfund, Gold*)
- the consonant 'k' in English is often a soft *c* in German (eg *Milch, Flasche*)
- the primary stress pattern of words such as *Garage, Sandale*.